It has been fascinating to learn the nuances of farm life over the past decade, and this has been imperative to keeping my brain from always thinking about cricket. The old shepherd's trick of bonding a lamb to a ewe whose lamb has died is to remove the skin of a dead lamb, and place it over the skin of an orphan lamb, in the hope it will be accepted by an adoptive mother. Instinct is powerful; a ewe will violently reject any lamb with an unfamiliar scent. If she allows it to suckle, you know you have had a successful adaption.

Another method is when the ewe's head is restrained for a short time, so that she cannot turn to see and smell which lamb is suckling. Her milk passes through the orphan, giving it her scent, and eight times out of ten she accepts it as her own. All the hard work, and consistent care, put in over the previous year is rewarded.

The breeding year begins in September, when the tup, the male, is put in with the females. His chest area is raddled, covered with an oil-based paint, which rubs off on the hindquarters of a receptive female. The paint colour is changed every two weeks, so that a timeframe of conception can be calculated and give a rough idea when she will give birth. A pregnant ewe will not accept a secondary attempt to mate. The ewe is then scanned ten weeks later, to see how many lambs she is carrying; the number is denoted by different-coloured dots.

The rearing process is surprisingly personal. You get to know the lambing shed, such as which ewes or lambs are vulnerable and need a careful eye over them for a few days. You begin to recognize lambs as distinctive individuals before they are turned out into a field. When it is very busy and 60–70 sheep are lambing every day for a few days, it's all hands to the pump. I once lambed for twenty-one consecutive nights when Alice wasn't feeling too great in the early stages of her pregnancy with Isobel. I was so tired. It made batting for ten hours in the Abu Dhabi heat seem fairly easy in comparison.

All this takes place on the family farm, about a mile from where we live. We graze sheep at home, along with cows, one of which did some freelance landscaping when it broke into the front garden. That's Jimmy Anderson's worst nightmare. Quite frankly, he's terrified of cattle. For some reason, he didn't believe me when I told him they quite liked being stroked.

I must admit it took me time to trust horses. Perhaps that stems from Mum's childhood warning never to stand behind one. It could also have